

**Regional Declaration of Press Councils in South East Europe and Türkiye
on the Ethical and Transparent Use of Artificial Intelligence in the Media**

Ohrid, 20 May 2025

Preamble

We, the representatives of the press and media councils from South East Europe and Türkiye, gathered in Ohrid (North Macedonia) at the Regional meeting on Media Ethics and the Responsible Use of Artificial Intelligence in the newsrooms.

Reminding the role of journalism in producing and disseminating public interest information, especially in times of crisis and electoral period, and emphasizing the overriding importance of this role remaining free from capture or distorting influence,

Highlighting the critical role played by media self-regulation in protecting the public interest and promoting responsible reporting in the digital era, by ensuring enforcement of journalistic ethical standards, helping minimize state intervention in the field of media freedom, and serving to decrease judicial action against the media,

Recalling ongoing threats to the safety of journalists in the region and alarmed by the resurgence of political threats to media independence, such as the abuse of State resources, including advertising, efforts by political figures to capture media, withdrawal of accreditation from journalists, harsh attacks which aim to stigmatise and discredit the media, and the targeting of the media through the abuse of judicial proceedings,

Acknowledging the growing impact of artificial intelligence (AI) on journalism, the media, and public discourse,

Recognizing its transformative potential, but also the risks it poses to ethical standards, professionalism, and public trust,

Recalling the efforts made by Press and Media Councils to upgrade the Codes of Ethics to include ethical use of AI in newsrooms,

Underlining the urgency of equipping journalists, media professionals and citizens with AI skills to enable them to navigate the evolving information landscape notably by the capacity to distinguish reliable from unreliable information and support professional journalism,

Acknowledging the statement on AI integration in newsrooms of South East Europe and Turkey adopted at the Regional Conference “The Trust Story: Pathways to Quality Journalism in South East Europe and Türkiye in the Digital Age”,

Aware of the crisis of media sustainability and the need for sources of funding to support public interest journalism and news media in the age of AI, including equitable sharing of revenues generated from trusted content by AI models.

Principles of the Declaration

AI as Support, not a Substitute

Artificial intelligence (AI) should serve as a tool to support journalists and newsrooms, but never as a replacement for human judgment, professional discernment, or editorial responsibility.

Transparency and Labelling of AI-Generated Content

The use of AI in the creation, selection, or processing of media content must be transparent and accountable. The public has a right to understand when and how AI meaningfully shapes the information they receive. Disclosure should be proportionate to the impact of the AI’s role. In particular, when AI significantly alters the presentation, framing, or substance of content—whether in text, image, audio, or video form—this must be clearly communicated to the audience. Special attention must be given to content that is fully or partially generated by AI, especially where the distinction from human-created content is not obvious. Such material should be clearly and visibly labelled. Manipulative forms of AI-generated content, such as deepfakes or synthetic voices, must not be published without appropriate ethical justification, warning, and context to inform the public of their nature.

Editorial Responsibility and Risk Assessment

Ultimate responsibility for media content must rest with journalists and editors. Before deploying AI systems - especially in high-stakes contexts such as elections, conflicts or public health crises - media organisations should conduct risk assessments that are both proportionate and context-sensitive, taking into account the potential impact on public trust, vulnerable communities and information integrity. Algorithms must not hold decision-making authority without meaningful human oversight

Credibility and Fact-Checking

All media content created or supported by AI is subject to the same standards for verification, accuracy, and ethical processing as content created without the use of AI.

Media Pluralism, Diversity, and Protection of Vulnerable Groups

Journalist should be aware that AI may reproduce or reinforce discrimination, bias, or harmful stereotypes and also create so called “information bubbles” that restrict access to diverse viewpoints and sources.

Accountability and Oversight in the Use of AI

Media should establish clear internal policies and guidelines for the responsible and ethical use of AI.

Privacy and Data Protection

The principles of personal data protection must be strictly observed in all uses of AI. The collection or processing of personal information without informed consent and appropriate legal basis is not permitted.

Education and AI Literacy

Systemic support is needed for educating journalists, media professionals, and the public on critical understanding and safe use of AI. AI literacy should become an integral part of media education and public awareness campaigns.

Modernizing the Ethical Framework

Effective mechanisms should be in place for complaints and intervention in cases of unethical or manipulative use of AI content generated.

Media as Guardians of Democracy

The media should retain their role as watchdogs of power, and AI should be employed in support of this democratic function. Algorithms should reinforce—not obscure—accountability, transparency, and the public interest.

Conclusion

At a time when artificial intelligence is becoming an increasingly integrated part of the media ecosystem, it is imperative that it be used ethically, responsibly, and transparently.

We, the signatories of this Declaration, commit to:

- Upgrading journalistic codes of ethics in light of new ethical challenges;

- Fostering cooperation and sharing best practices among self-regulatory bodies and media associations across the region;
- Ensuring continuous training for the responsible application of AI in media;
- Promoting public awareness and increasing critical AI literacy skills among journalists, media professional and citizens.

We are convinced that only through ethics, transparency, and a shared vision can we build a media system that is resilient, inclusive, and worthy of public trust in the digital era.

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